



AMERICA FIRST McCain, the PoW from Hanoi, has come a long way

■ By S. Prasannarajan in Washington D.C.

Two disparate life stories and one country that can turn them into a historic narrative in power and dream. In one story, in the library of the American Embassy in Jakarta, a black boy opens an old issue of *Life* and comes across "a photograph of an older man in dark glasses and a rain coat walking down an empty road". On the next page, the boy gets transfixed by a close-up of the man's hands. "They had a strange, unnatural pallor, as if blood had been drawn from the flesh. Turning back to the first picture, I now saw that the man's crinkly hair, his heavy lips and broad, fleshy nose, all had this same uneven, ghostly hue," the boy would write in his memoir, *Dreams from My Father*, years later. Reading the accompanying text, the boy learns, to his horror, that the man is a victim of a chemical treatment that promised to lighten his complexion. "There were thousands of people like him, black men and women back in America who'd undergone the same treatment in

response to advertisements that promised happiness as a white person." He feels sick: "I felt my face and neck get hot. My stomach knotted; the type began to blur on the page... As in a dream, I had no voice for my newfound fear."

In the other story, which takes place in the same decade of the Sixties, honour and courage take wings when a naval pilot parachutes into a lake in the city of Hanoi from his missile-hit A-4. In the next five-and-a-half years in captivity, he as a POW would suffer the worst forms of torture and refuse an offer of early release. He would not take advantage of the privilege of being the son of the commander-in-chief of the Pacific Command. "They were a lantern for me, a lantern of courage and faith that illuminated the way home with honor, and I struggled against panic and despair to stay in its light," he would write about his fellow prisoners. A forced confession would sear his soul but this young man of broken bones and unscarred conscience would not abandon faith. "In prison, where my cherished independence was mocked and assaulted, I found my